

Description: This was my final paper for my class on Myth, Philosophy, and Science, which I took my first semester of undergraduate studies. It explores how it a single theme, humans' terror of their own mortality, which has been conceptualized across several different explanatory systems: anthropology, psychology, and literature/ a mythological epic. This was written in my first semester freshman year, so while my writing has (hopefully) improved since then, I included it because this paper was the spark that drove me to study knowledge and ways of knowing.

All Men Must Die

Religion 065, Zlatko Plese

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I have seen the moment of my greatness flicker,
And I have seen the eternal Footman hold my coat, and snicker,
And in short, I was afraid.

T.S. Eliot, The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock

The slow march to our death begins the moment we emerge into this life. We spend our existence in an intense stalemate with the Grim Reaper. No matter what moves we make to wrestle ourselves from his grip, his smirk remains, as he knows he will never lose. Every triumphant accomplishment, the loves we have on this earth, the families we forge and memories we make will all be reduced to oblivion when our feeble meat sacks- nothing more than fluids sloshing around a carbon cage and clumps of cells- are buried in the ground, and degrade into food for worms. One day, none of our lives will matter. As T.S. Eliot alludes to in his poem, this fact is nothing short of terrifying. Yet, humans live their lives without constant existential dread, despite the fact that our descent into nothingness is near.

This terrifying yet intriguing fact of our mortality pervades our lives. It has prompted inquiry into the nature of humankind and how our death affects us. Indeed, across both anthropology, psychology, and literary traditions, humans have explored this question. This paper dives into the varied exploration into how we face our own mortality, and what different ways of thinking can tell us about this age old question.

One way to study this fact of human nature is to compare and contrast our nature against another living being: animals. One such man who has studied these distinctions is cultural anthropologist Ernest Becker, who concludes that humans are a problematic blend of animal and godlike

elements. In his Pulitzer Prize winning work of nonfiction, *The Denial of Death*, Becker reinterprets Freudian psychosexual theories into Neo-Freudian psychodynamic ideas. In other words, while Freud focuses on sex and aggression as a central tenet of humanity and the basis from which most other behaviors build, Becker extrapolates that the true central tenet driving behavior is awareness of our own mortality. He extrapolates this from many sources, including Freud's contemporaries Alfred Adler, Otto Rank and Carl Jung, as well as relying on existentialist philosophers such as Kierkegaard. He surmises the awareness of humans of their own mortality and its effects eloquently in his discussion of Kierkegaardian theory, in which he states:

“The fall into self-consciousness, the emergence from comfortable ignorance in nature, had one great penalty for man: it gave him dread, or anxiety. One does not find dread in the beast... “by nature the beast is not qualified by spirit”... For “spirit” read “self” or symbolic inner identity. The beast has none. It is ignorant, says Kierkegaard, therefore innocent; but man is a “synthesis of the soulish and bodily” and so experiences anxiety. Again, for “soulish” we must read “selfconscious.” If a man were a beast or an angel, he would not be able to be in dread. [That is, if he were utterly unself-conscious or totally un-animal.] Since he is a synthesis, he can be in dread (. . .) man himself produces dread” (Becker 1973, 69).

Our “fall into self consciousness,” otherwise known as our heightened awareness, separates us from other animals, and allows for the emergence of 1) dread and fear in the human race because we can conceptualize our mortality and eventual death and 2) the creation of a symbolic inner identity, or a “self” or soul. Interestingly, Becker notes that an “angel” would not experience dread, as divinities are totally conscious and un-animal. He characterizes humans as a

blend between the unconscious, mortal animals, and the totally conscious divinities, because they have both a soul and a corporeal body. The comparison between entities positions humans as semi-conscious beings, and implies humans' terror of their own mortality comes from their blend between animal and divine traits.

Similar to Becker, Jan Assman, in his book *Death and Salvation in Ancient Egypt*, which explores mythological constructs of death, contrasts humans to animals, and reaches the same conclusion that knowledge of death separates humans from animals. Thus, humans exist with a problematic blend between animal and godlike traits. He eloquently states the difference between animals and humans as the replacement of instinct with knowledge:

“Man lacks the instinctive, assured reaction of animals; instead, he has the freedom to invent himself through culture... Animals and plants know nothing of this destiny [to die]... they react only to actual stimuli and dangers... (or) trouble themselves with overarching intellectual cares. This is the ideal amount of knowledge for beings that must make do with a limited lifetime. The immortal gods, however, need much more, they must know everything. Indeed, they must not die.” (Assman 2014, 2-3)

Assman believes that while animals react only to immediate survival threats, humankind has a “surplus of knowledge that stems from the world of gods and alienates man from the world of living beings” (Assman 2014, 3). This knowledge is undesirable when combined with our animal mortality. Assman, like Becker, concludes that mortals are trapped between animals and divinities, having knowledge fit for the gods but a body unfit for that knowledge. Interestingly, the statement that the gods “need much more” is punctuated by a repeated use of the word “must.” It reminds us that though we are describing the gods, it is the humans who ultimately “need” this in order to understand their own, semi-conscious state.

Furthering our understanding of how humankind is related to the divine, Assman incorporates the Babylonian myth of Aadpa to illustrate the surplus of godly knowledge in animal bodies to characterize humankind. In this story, Ea, the god of wisdom, passes wisdom on to his mortal son Aadpa, but cannot pass on his godly immortality. Thus, Aadpa possessed “the knowledge of the gods, which was not fitting for a man,” a situation other Gods saw as “intolerable” (Assman 2014, 3). The Gods’ distress over Aadpa’s godly knowledge underscores the unfitness of divine knowledge in frail mortal bodies. Thus, humankind is fated to have divine knowledge unfit for their mortal, vulnerable animal bodies.

Becker and Assman both establish the problematic coexistence of elements of divinity and animality in humans. They assert that this mismatch is not ideal for humankind. Becker eloquently states the nature of this dilemma in his claim that humans are “gods with anuses” (Becker 1973, 51).

Both Becker and Assman recognize that this intolerable paradox of humankind’s existence has a powerful effect on the way in which humans live their lives. The brilliance of Becker’s theory is that it posits our overwhelming mortal dread warrants a drastic coping mechanism: the construction of immortality in symbolic selves that outlive the body. Symbolic immortality is satisfied through Becker’s immortality vehicle: the creation of meaning in one’s life that outlives the body. Becker surmises, “The single organism can expand into dimensions of worlds and times without moving a physical limb; it can take eternity into itself even as it gaspingly dies (Becker 1973, 3). Individuals attempt to earn their meaning through

“a cosmic specialness...¹ by carving out a place in nature, by building an edifice that reflects human value: a temple, a cathedral, a totem pole, a skyscraper, a family that spans three generations. The hope and belief is that the things that man creates in society are of lasting worth and meaning, that they outlive or outshine death and decay, that man and his products count” (Becker 1973, 5).

The fear of oblivion makes humans long for immortality, but because human nature is to be mortal and die, we must earn our immortality in a roundabout, symbolic way.

Assman agrees with the concept that due to our morality, we will attempt to extend our being symbolically, and furthers Becker’s ideas by diving deeply into how culture factors into this equation of the creation of symbolic meaning. “Culture [is] a space in which man, with his surplus of knowledge and his troubled spirit, can devise himself, exceed himself... Culture both opens up and delimits a horizon of meaning beyond the boundaries of our earthly life” (Assman 2014, 8). Though humans are mortal and doomed to die, cultures have existed for millennia, and thus it is easy to extrapolate that culture should also remain once we are gone, and so creating an immortality vehicle for our symbolic self through culture is one of the most efficient ways for mortals to create symbolic immortality.

Social scientists are not the only scholars who have explored this topic. Terror Management Theory is a Psychological Theory created in response to Ernest Becker’s speculations about how humankind attempts to deny death by creating immortality for

¹ It is no accident that humankind needs to be special, and that immortality projects rely on the achievement of a sense of worth in the grand scheme of things: This need for cosmic specialness is documented in Freud’s work on narcissism and today narcissism is recognized as both a pathological condition in its extreme, but also it is a normal human trait characterized that all humans have to some degree (Weiten 2022, 406). In the pathological sense, recent research has found that narcissists are outwardly braggadocious and self-obsessed because internally they harbor very low views of themselves, though not all narcissists are aware of this. Indeed, their “constant need for validation seems to stem from the highly fragile and precarious nature of their self-esteem” (Weiten 2022, 407). Freud focused on the fact that narcissism is an innate trait, and Becker’s leap of genius is ascribing the narcissistic for cosmic specialness directly to our knowledge and fear of death, as opposed to Freud, who attributed it to sex and aggression.

themselves symbolically. The theory is not sterile science, and even quotes the same passage from T.S. Elliot's poem *Prufrock*, but interestingly the creators of the Theory were able to apply Carl Popper's notion of falsifiability in order to convert an anthropological theory to a scientific one. Studies on Narcissism (see footnote 2) have revealed the role of low self-esteem (aka a lack of cosmic specialness) in causing narcissists to be increasingly self-centered and braggadocious. Studies have also shown a phenomenon called narcissist rage: which is when threats to one's "sense of self" are followed by explosive anger and hostility. These phenomenon in pathological narcissists all point to the fact that one's self-perception/ sense of cosmic specialness (or lack thereof) is a necessary element of normal human functioning. Becker makes the genius connection that this need for cosmic specialness is because of our mortality.

Becker presents a convincing logical argument, but it is not until Terror Management Theory arises that the theory gains some scientific support. The Creators of Terror Management Theory follow in the logic of Becker and Assman, stating in their initial paper on TMT that "What saves us is culture. Cultures provide ways to view the world—worldviews—that 'solve' the existential crisis engendered by the awareness of death" (Weiten 2022, 410) . The experimental way that this theory is tested is through manipulating an independent variable of mortality salience: "the degree to which subjects' mortality is prominent in their minds" by asking an experimental group to think about their own future death while the control group does not do anything to raise their mortality salience (Weiten 2022, 410-411). The dependent variable is participants' responses to various questions designed by the experimenters. Amongst hundreds of studies, causational links have shown that the experimental group with heightened mortality salience (1) hand[s] out harsher penalties to moral transgressors; (2) respond[s] more negatively to people who criticize their country; and (3) show more respect for cultural icons (such as a

flag) than control subjects. This need to defend one's cultural worldview may even fuel prejudice and aggression... Reminding subjects of their mortality leads to (1) more negative evaluations of people from different religious or ethnic backgrounds, and (2) more aggressive behavior toward people with opposing political views" (Weiten 2022, 411). These findings yields strong support to TMT, and indirectly to Ernest Becker and Jan Assman's theories that individuals must seek symbolic immortality because of their fear of their corporeal mortality, and that out of this culture is generated, shaped, and reutilized in future generations immortality projects.

Despite the fact that the scientific methods of Terror Management Theory added strong support to this theory, it is important to recognize the preexistence of these ideas. Indeed, even before Assman or Becker, I find that the generation of symbolic immortality through culture is described in depth in the myth, and early piece of human literature, the *Epic of Gilgamesh*. Gilgamesh's behavior is a powerful example of how the dread of death drives mankind to seek immortality, and the different solutions to the epic explore the types of immortality mankind may achieve. In the beginning of the epic, Gilgamesh fulfils what Becker would describe as a quest for immortality/ an immortality project through being a hero, committing glorious deeds to cultivate his immortal glory. Indeed, he states to Enkidu that "Who is there, my friend, can climb to the sky? Only the gods [dwell] forever in sunlight... If I should fall, let me make my name: 'Gilgamesh joined battle with ferocious Huwawa!'" (Abusch 2015, 133). He recognizes that corporeal immortality is only for the gods, and focuses on symbolic immortality of his name. However, as Tzvi Abusch states in his book *Male and Female in the Epic of Gilgamesh* that "the Akkadian Epic of Gilgamesh tells of courageous deeds, but it does this only to highlight the pain caused by these deeds and the new problems that must be faced (Abusch 2015, 130). Indeed, "his rule is oppressive" (Abusch 2015, 136). He neglects his duties as a king to pursue heroic deeds,

and thus harms his people. Thus, Gilgamesh's Heroism is a feeble solution to immortality, as it causes undue pain and burden to those around him. After Gilgamesh's best friend Enkidu dies, Gilgamesh is distraught, and refuses to give up his body for burial until a worm drops out of his nose, stating that "My friend perhaps will rise up to me at my cry!" (Abusch 2015, 116). The death of Enkidu dramatically raises Gilgamesh's mortality salience, and Gilgamesh denies that his friend is dead with his actions. The heroic vehicle for immortality again becomes unsatisfactory, as it is unable to stave off Gilgamesh's dread of death and an existential crisis, leading to an obsessive and fruitless search for true corporeal immortality.

Post the death of Enkidu, the forms of symbolic immortality that are explored are children, cultural development, and true corporeal immortality. The first solution is in Gilgamesh's encounter with Siduri, the divine barmaid. Her famous passage in response to Gilgamesh's uncontrollable dread is as follows:

"Gilgamesh, whither do you rove? The life that you pursue you shall not find. When the gods created mankind, Death they appointed for mankind, Life in their own hands they held... Look down at the little one who holds your hand, Let a wife ever be festive in your lap" (Abusch 2015, 114)

Siduri offers Gilgamesh a solution to symbolic immortality in the form of children, a legacy in the form of family.

But Siduri's solution is not satisfactory, and Gilgamesh ventures out to find Utnapishtim, the corporeal immortal who survives the Atrahasis great flood myth meant to exterminate humankind. Utnapishtim offers another solution of symbolic immortality by encouraging Gilgamesh to discard his animalistic wanderings in the woods, to reassume the role of a king and cultivate cultural achievement. What better way to cultivate cosmic specialness than to develop

culture? According to Assman, “Culture is man’s second nature. [mankind] cannot survive with only the first” due to our weak and feeble state when we are alone and without societal aids (Assman 2014, 2). Thus, serving culture and prolonging humanity is serving humanity’s collective immortality. Moreover, this cultural immortality solution constitutes a religious solution as well, because it is the will of the Babylonian gods that humankind must survive forever and escape oblivion. In the aftermath of the great flood, Ea convinces the other gods that while individuals should be killed, all of humankind should not be annihilated. Indeed, Ea states that “Instead of your bringing on the Flood, would that a lion had appeared to diminish the people!” (Gilgamesh XI). This demonstrates Gods will is for human civilization to continue to proliferate, and that only individual humans should die out. Thus, Gilgamesh is not selecting an immortality project of only cultural achievement, he is also selecting a religious immortality project, by choosing to follow the gods will. Religion and is a powerful symbolic immortality solution, as the individual connects their immortality to a durable symbol of immortality (divinity).

The final solution is true, corporeal immortality when Gilgamesh ascends to Godhood. However, this ascension is sour and Gilgamesh initially resists it. This is because, as Abusch notes, “the offer [of Godhood] thus constitutes immortality, but also a loss of actual human life” (Abusch 2015, 141). Previously, it is stated that from his birth, “two thirds of him [Gilgamesh is] God and one-third [is] human” (Abusch 2015, 140). Transitioning from human to God must be a “change of being” (Abusch 2015, 142). In choosing to become a full immortal and a full God, Gilgamesh loses his humanity. The loss of humanity is thus a true tragedy in this text: the unique blend of godliness with animal mortality is a special quality of humans, and it cannot exist in true immortals.

As *The Denial of Death*, Terror Management Theory, *Death and Salvation in Ancient Egypt*, *the Epic of Gilgamesh* and ultimately this paper posit, dread of death leads to culture and unique human behavior. However, Becker notes that angels and beasts alike have no knowledge of mortality and thus have no capacity for dread (Becker 1973, 69). Without dread, many vital characteristics of life: culture, meaning, family, legacy, and creation from within cease to exist. The very nature that leads us to fear oblivion is the source of our cultural joys, our loving families, our goals and ambitions, and the brilliant parts of being human. To be human is not to suffer because of our lack of goodlihood, it is to be “Gods with anuses”, in other words, it is to be Gods with mortality, and to accomplish beautiful and wonderful things that Gods, sin mortality, would not be able to do (Becker 1973, 51).

With this new, positive understanding of humanity and its characteristics as unique, let us revisit the story of Aadpa. As a reminder, Ea warns Aadpa that the Gods may be giving him fruit that will lead to his death, despite the fact that they intend to give Aadpa the fruit of life. It appears unlikely that the God of Wisdom would fully misunderstand the will of the Gods to make Aadpa immortal. Instead, with the understanding that the unique blend of humanity and goodlihood can be beneficial, and that Gilgamesh had to give up his humanity for true Godhood and thus *die* in a sense, perhaps it is more likely that Ea was correct that the fruit of life was actually the fruit of death: Ea may have understood all along that the uniqueness of mortality with godly knowledge could not coexist with immortality, and thus humanity dies when it receives immortality.

The nature of humans is infinitely complex; to be human is to exist in a blended state between animals and the divine. We differ from animals because we have an advanced capacity for knowledge and self-awareness, which allows us to understand our own inevitable

doom, and we differ from divinities because of our lack of corporeal immortality. This awareness of our ultimate oblivion affects us deeply, and causes us to invent symbolic immortality, aka a legacy of some sorts for ourselves, in order to not go mad. But our mortality confers benefits to us as well; Without dread of our death, our Godlike powers of creation of meaning are hindered. We create beauty and culture not only despite the inevitability of oblivion, but because we are mere worm food, in a way that an animal or a God could not accomplish. The loss of humanity is thus something to be dreaded, and thus symbolic immortality is a superior solution to true immortality.

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